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Evan Christopher

Clarinetist Evan Christopher was born in 1974 in Long Beach, California. He is a graduate of the Idyllwild School of Music and the Arts and California State University. Evan moved to New Orleans in 1994 and has become a major exponent of the rich clarinet tradition of the Crescent City. His recordings include "Clarinet Road" (Volumes 1 & 2), "Django a la Creole," and "Delta Bound."

Evan was interviewed on October 1, 2009 in Clinton, New York, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: Welcome to Hamilton College, Evan Christopher.

EC: Thank you, Monk.

MR: It's been a pleasure listening to you play the last couple of days, and I wanted to follow-up on some things you've said so I hope you don't mind repeating yourself. One thing that I found that was interesting —

EC: I don't know that I can repeat myself.

MR: Okay. I'll bet you can. When the students were asking you about making a living and how's the music business, and I think I asked you the same thing, you sounded like you were semi-joking, but that you said I wish the music business was a little worse, because then I would do something else.

EC: Yeah. Things are bad, but if they would just get a little bit worse then I would be forced to do something else. Yeah. Meaning that of course at the end of the day I mean there's a lot of great things about being a musician, but then, you know, there's aspects of it that are daunting and — I just turned 40 — and there is something about that number that makes it a little — something about that number that started making it a little harder to determine whether or not I had enough fortitude or energy to continue to deal with the adversity aspects of it, like travel for instance.

MR: You said you're on the road more than 100 days a year.

EC: Probably closer to 150. And I only calculate that but they say I'm gone three months for the summer, that's 90, and if I'm gone a week during the other months of the year, that's 63 days left over, so that's about 150 days. So it's got to be somewhere around there. It certainly can't be any less.

MR: I'm going to ask you to move your mic out a little bit. I just don't want to have an issue with that later. And the adversity of being — are you your own manager so to speak?

EC: I don't have management right now. Yeah. So it's something that I'm considering

they demand different types of marketing or negotiating skills, but that's starting to come and that's something that's not an area that I want to be expending energy in also.

MR: That kind of leads me to my question I had, and if you're 40 and you've been doing it for quite a while now, is there an end game in sight for you? Does a musician say if only I could get to this level?

EC: I'm sure some musicians do. I've never operated with those types of goals. Everything's been a little more improvised. I think at the end of the day, no, I don't even have that — I haven't even managed to have the expectation of a certain level of stability or a certain number to show on an income tax form, not that I remember what those look like either, but I'm not sure I've ever managed to have very concrete visions of things that were going to happen. I've been pretty loose.

MR: Is part of what you're trying to do for the next stage of your career though, you mentioned doing your own music.

EC: More and more.

MR: What do you mean by that?

EC: Well I'm starting to write more. I have a couple of projects coming up where I'll be working closely with orchestrators and doing, actually framing the New Orleans style of clarinet playing in orchestral contexts and pieces with string quartets, and different textures. It's been fun to explore the New Orleans clarinet just through the lens of more contemporary settings of jazz, but even that's not far enough away. It just seems to be, it needs to really be polished and given a different setting. You know, put the stone in a setting that's really dramatically unexpected. I think that's the next step.

MR: This New Orleans clarinet tradition. I would have to guess this was not something that you sat down and said where's a niche for me, and then recognized this niche and pursued it.

EC: No the niche revealed itself. The niche revealed itself. Because you have to remember, Monk, when I actually moved to New Orleans in 1994, there were no clarinetists left for me to study with directly. Willie Humphrey would have been the last and he passed away just months before my arrival to the city. So it's not that the style revealed itself to me as my niche, it's just that I kept finding it strange that the only clarinetists that I enjoy were gone, were in recordings, I mean in New Orleans proper. And of course this was also a year before I met Kenny Davern, so this was a year before I'd spent time in New Orleans, working in New Orleans, realizing that the language of the clarinet had style-specific elements that are what made it so special and unique. This was before, this was a couple of years before I discovered the Creole clarinets of the Caribbean, of Martinique and the French West Indies. So there was a lot of vocabulary that I hadn't really gotten to yet,

even when I first moved to New Orleans there was a lot of vocabulary I didn't — that had captured my ear enough to check it out, but I hadn't really incorporated it.

MR: Did your music education that you went through — you got a Bachelor's —

EC: I did. For my dad. For my father.

MR: Oh, explain if you would.

EC: It was important to him that I finish school.

MR: Oh, for your dad. I see, yeah. Yeah, if you just have that under your belt.

EC: Yeah. He wouldn't worry so much.

MR: So the theoretical parts of learning music stuff, did that help you or hinder you in understanding what players like Sidney Bechet —

EC: Oh, no, it completely helped. It completely helped. Yeah. Even later, there were holes. If I had learned more, for instance, about analysis. If I had learned more about how to break performance practice down into elements. If I had learned more about how to organize and identify schemas and protocol for performing the music, which comes through study of — I think comes from formal study of European classical music and the types of courses that I guess I would have had access to if I'd continued music education or had pursued it on a deeper level than just an undergraduate degree, then I think I would have been even a little faster at it. And now the holes are becoming more obvious. I'm starting to write for orchestra. Now some gaps are really starting to become daunting. Fortunately I have associations with orchestrators and people like that who can help me out. Even on a technical level I think I didn't take advantage of the resources that I had in university, just for sound recording, for even computer technology, I didn't take advantage of having a better understanding of business models. In the last couple of years I've been involved in projects that are pursuing 501c3 status and learning how to write mission statements and things like this and business plans or even how to have a strategic planning meeting. So it's not just the craft of the music that, you know there's a lot of aspects of music that you can kind of learn by doing, but learning by doing is a really hard way to do things. And there's no harm in having some background in these areas, and there's nothing that formal study — formal study can't ever take away anything from how one engages one's experiences. You know what I mean? We're always, ultimately we're going to learn more from our experiences than we're going to learn from something in a book. But if we've seen it in a book first it can never hurt it I don't think.

MR: As Dan Barrett said, taking about, someone asked him about modes. He said, "Well all knowledge is good, you just have to know when to use it or not."

EC: Well and Dan's point is well taken. I mean there's a lot of things that I learned about that I don't really have any use for. I think it's more of just the discipline of having learned

wonderful things about what you could play over a G7 that had absolutely nothing to do with G7, but is that information that I use in my gigs? No. Not really. But there's still a math to it, and there's still a lens to learn how to listen through music through certain lenses. There's still ways to learn how to do that. And any time you're introduced to something new and can return to those methods and be more efficient at it, even if it's not — whether it's information you're going to use or not use, you're still going to be more efficient with it.

MR: Did you have preconceptions about what New Orleans was going to be like, and how were they met when you got there?

EC: No. I didn't have any preconceptions about it. It was like when I woke up there, in the context of this tour that I was on, I think we drove all night from Chicago as a matter of fact. We'd had a job in Chicago and I think we drove the whole night to wake up in the morning. This was in July of 1994. And it really was like nowhere else I'd ever been. It was — the air was in a way like nothing I'd ever felt. I mean I knew what humidity was, I'd been to Washington, D.C. once in the summertime and I'd been places, but this was different. Different smells, different — so much of it was different. I didn't have expectations. I was surprised how quickly I had work, almost as much work as I wanted.

MR: Really?

EC: I was surprised at how quickly I found a community of peers, young guys, some definitely were younger than me, some guys a few years older than me, that could sit around a restaurant at breakfast and talk about CDs we just bought and stuff like that, and, "Oh you got the new Louis Armstrong box set?" So I think that there's a level of community that surprised me, there was a level of acceptance that was a little disarming and I still don't know what to do with that aspect of it.

MR: Were those people that were so accepting of you all natives?

EC: Probably half and half.

MR: Yeah.

EC: And at the time I don't think I made as much of a distinction. But that was disarming. So no, I didn't have any expectations. There was a point, pretty soon though, within only a year and a half or so, where I was already — definitely not bored — but I definitely felt like okay, well all right, there didn't seem to be this infinite ceiling or it didn't seem like there were infinite possibilities for the music, at least not in the context that I was in. I didn't see that yet. I wasn't really acutely aware of what was happening creatively. I spent a year and a half just seeing what I could do with New Orleans music and how quickly I could kind of find a way to apply or feel like I was anchored in what to me represented a very specific tradition with very style-specific elements to it, to the point

MR: Well I was going to ask, if you're trying to play and you're trying to absorb and learn the style of people who were playing almost a hundred years ago, is some of it dependent on what kind of accompaniment you're getting? And if it's not there —

EC: I struggled with that. I still struggle with that. I mean there being a disparity. Not as much, I've kind of figured it out, but yeah it was really interesting to recognize that there was going to be a disparity, not with just the rhythm section and the accompaniment but even with the other musicians, even the brass players. If I'm in the front line and I got the trumpet player not really playing a whole lot of melody and playing bebop, you know, the counterpoint ends up being a little bit different. It's not unfamiliar to me because my background was already coming from more modern music. My dilemma was trying to figure out how to still feel like I was staying appropriate to the style. And that's what I mean about being defensive about those, or a little more, not conservative about the shoulds and shouldn'ts of using those elements of style, but just the shoulds and shouldn'ts of their presence. Meaning look, it should be possible for me to be in the front line and not have to change my style to fit in. I should be able to still be a New Orleans clarinetist regardless of what the rhythm section is doing. I should be able to be a New Orleans clarinetist even if I'm not playing a traditional New Orleans song. I should be able to feel right to do this. Louis Armstrong did it. Louis Armstrong recorded with Oscar Peterson's trio and he didn't really change a thing about what he was doing. You know what I mean? So hearing Louis Armstrong on records like that was for me just puzzling to me. It was like okay, how does one do that? Switching to the Albert system, which I hadn't done yet when I first moved to New Orleans, helped a lot. I didn't switch to the Albert system until I left New Orleans the first time and went to San Antonio, Texas.

MR: For Jim Cullum engagements?

EC: Right. It was for the Jim Cullum Jazz Band. And it was being able to work six nights a week, it gave me a period of time to switch back and forth until eventually I phased out the Boehm system entirely. But I wasn't playing — I was still playing the Boehm system when I first moved to New Orleans. I didn't switch to the Albert system until — I was experimenting with the Albert system in New Orleans.

MR: From a finger standpoint some of the effects and the sounds that those players like Sidney Bechet and Omer Simeon — do you think it helps to have that instrument then?

EC: It helps me.

MR: It helps you. Okay.

EC: And I'm constantly looking for things that are specific to this fingering system. You know I compose just to almost make a point that the New Orleans style has to be done on the Albert system. There's things that I'll put in. I'll put things in certain keys so that they

Albert system clarinet until almost, until closer to 2000 I guess. So that was problematic as well. It helps me. It helps me feel like I'm more in there. Sort of like you can have a computer font that looks like an old typewriter ribbon, but it's not really the same as typing on a typewriter.

MR: Well let me follow-up on a couple of things you had said to the students this morning. I like the idea of trying to dispel some myths about the early days of this music. And that your statements were that much of the change in music happened because of economics and what people wanted and what club owners wanted.

EC: Or just the limitations of the resources. Musicians, music, whole bands, famous bands have been formed not because of someone's creative whims but just because of what was available or not available. Right? Gerry Mulligan and Chet Baker.

MR: Oh right.

EC: Perfect example. What if there's not a piano in the club, then guess what, we're not playing the piano. It wasn't necessarily — musicians always adapt to their circumstances. Even when we were taking about vibrato. You live in a city that doesn't have air conditioning and it's really hard on pianos and keeping them in tune. Musicians adapt. You find strategies to make the music sound good even when there's things working against you. Yeah I believe that. I believe that especially in books they don't pay enough attention to how musicians' pragmatic choices are more responsible for their decisions. People want to think that it's all artistic whims, right down to the solos we play. "Oh King Oliver played the blues because he was expressing the angst of his race." You know? Even my friends joke about it, you mean like King Oliver played the blues because someone asked for a blues. Someone requested a blues. Or King Oliver played a blues because the song before it was fast. I'm not saying that musicians don't make artistic decisions, of course I'm not saying that. I'm just saying that a lot of times that people seem to forget, especially in New Orleans music it's really good for reminding us of this, of just the pragmatism. New Orleans music, it doesn't deny that — New Orleans jazz never denies that it has great potential for artistic expression. It's not that, we're not saying that it's not capable of being felt on that same level. I mean I'm just saying that at the end of the day it's the work conditions and the weather and people's reliability. It's the way clubs are structured. It's the way music is marketed. All these things — it's the amount that a job pays that dictates what I do on any particular day more than — it's how long the sets are supposed to be.

MR: Well even composers like Handel wrote what they were told to sometimes. The Count said I need dance music for —

EC: I guess what I started to say is even though we're not apologizers for the potential for the

the experience. People can enter the experience of New Orleans music on as many levels as they want. I mean I had, before I came up here I worked — when I came up to New York on a Tuesday, I came here to do some of the outreach on Wednesday, which I'm very grateful for, I'm really starting to get where I don't want to ever just go up and do a concert anymore, I just don't want to do that, I really think it's important, especially if there are students that are coming, I really feel like I have a responsibility to let them know something about what they're going to hear. So I'm really grateful to have that opportunity. But New Orleans music just doesn't apologize for being entertaining. There's something about the modern jazz aesthetic to me that seems like there's either two ways, it's the, "I'm going to dare you try to enjoy this" or it's going to be — so there's that aspect of it, and you sure the hell ain't going to dance to it, oh no, ut uh. There's that, and then there's almost a, "Well what I'm doing is really intellectual but you can enjoy it too." So there's two sides of it, where there's like an apology involved and New Orleans music just doesn't work on that level. So the three jobs I did before I came up this weekend were: one of them was on the steamboat Natchez playing the dinner cruise, which was beautiful, the river is beautiful at 6:00, the sun is just setting and you're playing and you go down river and you play a couple of sets of music and people dance or have a beer on the deck of the boat or whatever they want to do. So that was something that has its own forum. I played another club the next night which was just a bar at one of the famous restaurants, Antoine's, they opened up a new bar facing the street. It's a terrible room for music. It's one of those rooms that's so bad for music that the only time that the music has the chance of becoming good is when there's nobody there. But of course from a business standpoint that doesn't work very well. But people can sit a little closer and listen if they want or they can sit a little farther away and talk and have a good time. You don't have an expectations of what the audience is supposed to be. And then I had another job in one of the new jazz clubs that's reopened. There's finally a jazz club on Bourbon Street again. And this club is the same way. It's big enough that if people want to talk they actually don't bother you that much. But it's also big enough that when they talk, depending on where they're sitting, you can't really hear what's happening. And in all those situations, like that last one — and then I had my regular band on Monday, which is a quartet and we turn this bar and it's like a jazz club the way you think of it. I mean all of a sudden I've got 40 people up in there on a Monday night just listening to the music and drinking nice cocktails. Everything is different. And if in any of those situations people wanted to talk or people wanted to dance there is always a place for them to do that. There's always a place, there's always an acceptance of them to enter the experience on whatever level they want and to provide

aficionado and a tourist that wants to hear "The Saints Go Marching In" — if you can appeal to both those people at the same time because of the level of musicianship, I mean I think that's when you've got success, that's the best example of when New Orleans music works.

MR: Well said. Do all those things, for you, they add up during your particular week, into that week's income?

EC: No.

MR: No.

EC: No, they don't. The jobs I do in New Orleans are mostly for some visibility, for experimenting with some things I'm working on musically and playing with good musicians. Most of my income is from touring. Oh, okay, it's a little bit of spending money, it's grocery money, it's, you know, I mean I suppose if I saved it at the end of the day I might have something to show for it and I don't work in town very often. I'm usually pretty picky. The musicians either have to be cats that I just would never say no to. You know if the drummer Shannon Powell calls me for a job I don't say no. If it's an opportunity for me to work with the musicians that I've hand selected to play some of my own music, I don't say no. But I also, I'm starting to have higher expectations of the venues. I've been pushing, in the last — since I've returned — well after the flooding I went away for a while. I accepted an artist residency in Paris. I didn't start coming back until about a year later when I was touring with a big band, and started having to commute back and forth from Europe, which I did for a good portion of 2007. And then somewhere along the way around early 2008 I started spending more time in New Orleans. A buddy of mine had had a baby in Germany so he was gone all the time, so I was able to stay at his place without having to have my own apartment. Then finally in late 2008 I got my own apartment. But in that period, about 2008, 2009, when I started making more of a commitment to saying I guess I am coming back, because at first I didn't think I was, I didn't think I was going to come back.

MR: Did you lose everything?

EC: Almost everything. Yeah. Not quite everything. I could have lost that. It wasn't where it should have been. It wasn't with me. It was in the apartment.

MR: Oh you weren't in New Orleans.

EC: I was in California for work. But because of the climate where I was going I didn't want to take my best instrument with me, which is this one. So it was there. If it had been a foot higher or if it had been in a different room in the apartment I would have lost it.

MR: How long was it before you could go back?

EC: I went back in October. The flooding was August 29 and I stayed in California close to

operation in early October I believe. Yeah, I suppose it would have been late October, or early October when I came back. Because by late October I remember being in New York City, so I know it must have been earlier on in October.

MR: What would you say to people who take the attitude why are people living there and why should we as a government pay to make it possible for them to live in the same place again?

EC: Well I mean there's a lot of things you would say. I mean for one thing it's the government's fault that the flooding happened to begin with. It was the failure of the federal levies that caused the flooding. Yes, there was a hurricane involved. And there was some wind damage. But the flooding happened because of breaches in the federal levy system. Not just one or two breaches but double digits. I mean there were places where the levies were compromised because they hadn't been built correctly to begin with. And the Army Corps of Engineers, that's not locals from New Orleans, it's not knowing how to build a levy. That's the federal government. And that's also the federal government not protecting the wetlands of the Gulf Coast, not holding the businesses and the oil companies and the gas fields more accountable for protecting the natural barrier that exists on the Gulf Coast. So for one thing there's some accountability of which people need to be reminded. The second thing is that I don't fault people for not having an understanding about how culturally significant, or economically significant, New Orleans is. People don't necessarily realize how much commerce comes up from the Gulf into the Mississippi River. That barge traffic, or that barges are still the cheapest way to transport large amounts of goods for imports and exports of sugar, rice, grain, steel. I mean it's still the cheapest way to move these products. I don't expect people to know that. I also don't not understand people's view, a more cynical view, of just how some spending is not, spending in this country is not done well, especially when it comes to kind of development things. I mean I can understand the cynicism that develops. I mean I became cynical too to find out that two things that happen when you have a situation like this is that the government can give no bid contracts, they can give the contracts for rebuilding to whoever they want, and it's no coincidence that they went to subsidiaries for Halliburton — Smith, Root & Brown — and other local companies that were basically very key for electing officials in the Republican administration. There is also something where they can really make it easier for immigration policies in this time of emergency. So I can understand how people would be very cynical about, you know, all of a sudden, what happened? How come there's all of a sudden this huge influx of people from Mexico, El Salvador, Columbia, Central America you know, coming in and not having to go through the same process of people who are legally trying to get here and all

might have moved back to New Orleans to help rebuild their own city. I mean there's all sorts of things and dynamics of it that are not hard to understand, but at the same time it's disconcerting to realize that our country, for all the greatness of our resources, on two fronts has not embraced our own culture as something that's kind of collectively ours to share and be proud of. But we're also not really looking at each other as being one community. And those are the kind of two disconcerting things that show a real disconnect and a lack of compassion in situations like this. I think that's something on a global level I think there's a disconnect there that's sort of part of the same cancer that makes it possible for whole nations to be rather insensitive to one another's situation or needs and a lack of understanding and empathy that at the end of the day, and we're close to the end of the day in a way, this planet is sort of ours to share and one person having things and another person not having things is, there may be some justice in it economically but unless everybody's bailing water out of the boat together it doesn't matter how much you have when you go down. So yeah, ironically, Monk, you know it's funny about New Orleans is when people, I don't know what it is, if it's something about me personally, but I've talked to other people that the same thing happens with them. There are many places in New Orleans that have not changed a bit since August 29, 2005. I did some work at a high school recently that didn't have any, they barely had anything before the storm, now they've got even less. And this high school is in the lower ninth ward and they are still in temporary buildings next door to where their school is. And George Washington Carver has a beautiful energy, the students have a beautiful energy in spite of how little they've been given to work with and in spite of how blighted their portion of the community is. Whereas not very far away in another part of the ninth ward, the Vietnamese rebuilt their schools and houses so fast they attracted the international attention of BNP Paribas and Ricoh Copiers, Ricoh Office Supplies, and got sponsorship to kind of rebuild. So yeah, there's some disparity in the way people chose to enter this phase of recovery. But it's funny, when people were saying, "Hey, so things in New Orleans, they're back to normal, right?" I find myself getting defensive, saying, "hell no, they're not back to normal." And I'll tell them about this high school and I'll tell them about areas and houses in my own neighborhood that are still abandoned. And by the same token, if someone says, "Yeah, I can't go back to New Orleans, man, things probably are really still terrible down there." I find myself being the opposite and saying, "No, we're ready for you, come on down, come and take a visit and see for yourself." And you can say both things about it simultaneously. You can say that yeah, four years later we're still in business and there's still a lot of great music to be heard and you can still go to second lines on a Sunday and the food and music culture is still more unique

experience it. And at the same time I can say yeah, this place is, we're still fighting over how to rebuild the hospitals. We're still fighting over how to rebuild schools. We're still arguing about what we're going to do have more significant levy protection for future floods and it's a mess. You can say those things simultaneously. It's all part of a whole.

MR: When my wife and I were there it was shortly before Katrina and we got to see at least one of the corner brass bands playing. It looked to be high school-aged kids. And having witnessed it for the first time, I thought it was really neat, also the fact that they were playing, I remember them playing "Stand By Me" with this funky second line groove or something. And I just was enthralled by it. And I wondered what motivates that aged kid to do that? Do you have any idea?

EC: What motivates them to pick up instruments?

MR: I'm assuming that they're carrying on a tradition. But that could be an incorrect assumption.

EC: No, no, of course it's a tradition. You interviewed Wendell Brunious, one of the New Orleans musicians that's — I showed you that picture of him when he was like six or seven years old standing there with his sister watching, well I guess it was the Olympia band, oh no, it might have been the Tuxedo. His father played in the Tuxedo band. So of course it's a tradition. But it's evolved a little bit. The marching bands of St. Augustine High School, that's a coveted membership in this marching band. It's a thing of honor. They get to travel and I think they were in the Rose Bowl parade in California. The brass band tradition for a lot of these young students of New Orleans, the marching, the brass band, is really their point of reference for instrumental music and their point of entry into the experience of playing music. There's not a lot of formal music programs in the schools. They are still being cut left and right as much as we want to be able to say yeah, we know how essential music is. Well the contradiction is that our schools, we still have principals that are cutting music programs. Even this year we lost two or three. So it's not that New Orleans is superior because we value music more, it doesn't work like that. But these kids have been to Mardi Gras parades and seen, by the time they're old enough to play an instrument they've seen dozens of brass bands, they've seen dozens of marching bands, they've had funerals where there was a band performing for the person who died and they've walked behind. They've known musicians in their community. They know what musicians look like. So yeah, the tradition, the exposure is there. No one is thrusting instruments in their hands and saying hey check this out, like they have to do everywhere else. They're waking up with it and they have older brothers and sisters that went to the same school. Just driving down the street, you know, kids are funny, they get out of band practice and some of them don't put their horns back in their case, they're still at the bus

with drumsticks and you can still see a high school kid walking down the street home from school with a sousaphone wrapped around his head. So you don't see that every day in other cities. I know it's not true. But I see it. I mean maybe I don't see it every day but yeah, every day I can see some evidence that yeah, there is music here happening. Now do we want the paradigm to be the brass band playing funky music? I mean in some of these music programs we have whole marching bands and there is only a handful of kids that can actually read music. So I don't necessarily want that to be the only paradigm. I think we owe it to them to give them more proper music instruction, more traditional music instruction if you will. I think they should all know how to read music. I think the older musicians and the college students, they need to be taking more responsibility for mentoring the little kids and our primary school and our middle school kids. I think the high school kids could even have that role, that continuum of that mentoring tradition has been lost. I don't think the musicians that you heard are following the professional bands around. I don't think that they've gone and taken music lessons with Wendell Brunious, the trumpet players that you heard in this band. Well he doesn't live in New Orleans now anyway, he lives in Sweden, but when he was around, I don't think they were going to him. Shannon Powell is right there in the Treme across the street from Armstrong Park, and I don't think kids are coming to him all the time for drum lessons. So it goes both ways. There is a tradition but at the same time it's not, there's a generation that's been skipped. When I talk to Shannon Powell or Herlin Riley or any of the musicians, or even if you talk to Wynton Marsalis, they will tell you about the mentoring that they had from the professional musicians that grew up around them or that they had exposure to. They'll talk about Danny Barker. Shannon will talk about Cié Frazier. Herlin will talk about musicians in his church. So that generation of musicians, who are maybe just a little bit older than me, still remember when they followed people around and that was how they got schooled in music. Leroi Jones will talk about the Fairview Baptist Church and even musicians a little bit younger than me like "Trombone Shorty" Andrews. If you got it out of him he would tell you about Anthony "Tuba Fats" Lacen. He would tell you about how he did have musicians in this community who were telling him how to get his shit together. So I think when you see a brass band of young kids I think you can recognize that there is definitely aspects of the musical tradition because of the exposure that they've had but I won't say that they've had the same — I won't say that the tradition is such that they actually learned their craft at the feet of older musicians.

MR: You know I have yet to hear you use the word "Dixieland." I think.

EC: I don't use it very often.

MR: And it's a word that carries connotations with it.

EC: And that's why I don't use it. I think for me it's a pejorative term for the music that creates a lot of misunderstanding about the New Orleans tradition. Even friends of mine, colleagues of mine in New York don't have, they don't give me evidence they really have any understanding of New Orleans' music, its significance to them, and they certainly don't know any of the repertoire. But I think there's a New York sort of Dixieland tradition that I think they understand better. And the reason I don't use it is because historically the first time you think of Dixieland you think of the Original Dixieland Jazz Band, which to me is almost an oxymoron because it wasn't really a jazz band. You have to remember that, yeah, these musicians were from New Orleans but they weren't improvising musicians, not at first, not when they first came up as young men. They were playing the music as a novelty music. It was similar to the way they played the music in New Orleans. But it wasn't really the way they played the music in New Orleans. And I think, for better or worse, the style changed. But for me, right away that connotation of the music being more for novelty doesn't do it justice when I speak about it, so I usually do purposely avoid the word. But there are instances where I use it and I don't mean it in a pejorative way or I mean I think, when I think of the New York Dixielanders, I mean and the cats who played at Nick's and Condon's and the Metropole, I mean those are some of my heroes too. Those are some of my heroes as well. And some of the first music I heard, before I really knew anything about New Orleans music were west coast Dixieland type bands. I think the first solo I ever transcribed, well there were two, the first solos that I ever transcribed were clarinet solos and one of them was Johnny Dodds "Struttin' with some Barbeque" with Louis Armstrong's Hot Five, and I mean I still remember [plays]. I mean that was one of the first songs. But the other solo I learned was by a clarinetist named Bill Napier, who was with the West Coast Dixieland Band, one of the trombonists named Bob Scobey. And the solo was on "Bill Bailey." And I remember that too. [plays] I mean so I listened to a lot of those recordings and it didn't — and in California my early experiences were probably more Dixieland-type experiences than they were New Orleans experiences, the difference being, obviously, one was a little more commercial, arrangements maybe a little bit more clever or slicker, and yeah, I mean I played hardware store openings where the band leader gave me a straw hat out of the back of his truck before I put the horn to my face. So yeah, of course, we had that. And I even subbed at Disneyland. I even subbed with a little band out there at Disneyland. Well I mean not very often but I mean so I saw that. But ironically, ironically Disneyland was the first time that I think I was conscious of how New Orleans clarinet sounded differently than Dixieland clarinet. At Disneyland there was, toward the end of the day, they'd get ready for a parade and they'd have all these speakers spaced

actually just came up out of the ground and so the parade had its own soundtrack. But in the interim, before they got ready for the parade they played some music of some musicians that used to be at Disneyland and one of them was a Louisiana clarinetist. He wasn't New Orleans, in fact it was Baton Rouge, but he worked with Kid Ory. His name was Joe Darensbourg. And he ended up on the west coast. And Joe had a wonderful kind of Creole sound on his clarinet and it was I remember one of the first times I remember being very conscious that this is different than like Benny Goodman or Artie Shaw or any of the Swing Era clarinet players that I loved so much. And it really tickled me. And it was probably about that time that I was getting to know George Probert, who worked with the original Firehouse Five Plus Two. And he played clarinet with Kid Ory too, clarinet and soprano sax. And George gave me a lot of recordings of New Orleans cats and everything like that. So I'll say for that reason also, just my personal experience of working in California, I recognize that there is a huge difference between Dixieland and New Orleans music. And when I really began to try to appreciate how New Orleans music is connected to the culture of the city, the cultural life of the city, and how the more commercial side of it resembled what I did as a young musician in California resembled what musicians in New Orleans did maybe for the tourists. You understand what I'm saying?

MR: Yes I do.

EC: I'm not saying that one is completely devoid of commercialness, and I'm not saying that the other is completely devoid of being culturally relevant. I'm not saying that either. I'm just saying that if they fall on one side or another, I'd rather — I feel that I can be a stronger advocate for the traditions if I'm framing them in the context of it being something that's historically, socially and culturally important rather than framing it as in a novelty offshoot or a throwback from, not to be considered on the same level as the artistic jazz tradition. So that's why I intentionally — that's the very long version of why I don't use the word Dixieland.

MR: It's all very interesting. Before we run out of tape here, I wanted to ask you about your relationship with Kenny Davern, who was a very loved man.

EC: I met Kenny in New Orleans. He came and visited New Orleans in the mid-nineties to play a little private jazz party of sorts with some other friends of ours: Dan Barrett and I think Snooky Young was on that gig. I think, oh I'm trying to remember who the other musicians were. I'm not going to remember off the top of my head. Damn I can't remember who else was in the band. Oh, Ralph Sutton was the piano player, because he came with us too. And Kenny had a longtime friend, Frank Laidlaw, who was living in New Orleans at the time. And Frank and I were buddies. And then when Kenny came to

the cemeteries, and we went by Larry Shields' house in the Garden District uptown somewhere, and we just rode around. I think we probably ate lunch, I don't remember where though. And I went to the concert that night, and that was about '95, so I was about 25 years old. And I knew who he was a little bit with his work with some of the Soprano Summit things. But I wasn't really involved and I wasn't really doing any types of jazz type parties or anything like that. None of that scene was really on my radar. I knew who Dan was because he was from southern California, Dan Barrett. And I think Dan and I had met on the bandstand a couple of times in California, but I'd never met Kenny before. And we had a blast. And I never, there was never a warming up period. He was kind to me pretty much from the beginning. He gave me a bit of fatherly advice when I took the job in San Antonio, he said, "Save your money." He didn't know me well enough to say anything else. He didn't know me well enough to say here's how you need to do this, here's how you need to wrap your head around doing a job six nights a week. He didn't really know me well enough to say anything but save your money. But we got to know each other over the years and I bought some of his clarinets. This is one of his clarinets. We ran into each other in Europe a couple of times over the years. We played a concert for the JVC Jazz Festival together and rode around taxis in New York a little bit and went to music stores. We always enjoyed each other company. I have three mentors who play my instrument: George Probert, his mantra was "practice," "strive for tone." One of my other mentors was Tony Scott, who next to Buddy DeFranco was like the most significant clarinetist of the bebop period. Tony's mantra, I think it was if there could be one it would be "everybody's bullshit." And it wasn't a sour grapes thing, I mean he just really was just — and Kenny didn't really have a mantra but I always pretend that his mantra was "fuck 'em all with the help of God."

MR: Really.

EC: Which is I mean that must sound horribly negative but what I think people need to remember about cynical, about what looks like cynicism to people, I think what they have to remember is that there's a type of cynicism that's actually only possible because of very high standards and ideals, which actually, ironically, in my opinion, is a very high form of optimism. And I think for that reason I think cats like Kenny were often misunderstood. I think cats like Kenny had such high standards and such a firm system of values, especially when it came to music but when it came to all things, that in the absence of being in the company of people who wanted to engage them rationally and to say engage them rationally, basically share their values, in the absence of people who shared their values and opinions of things, I think those are the people that probably had really a more difficult time.

MR: I can attest to that. Because when I didn't know him very well I thought he was very, very cynical, but then when I got to talking to him on the phone about what kind of group can we put together next year and the detail and the concern he went to: well if we have a trombone then we have to have this and we can't have just a trumpet and clarinet. I mean he was really, really concerned. I mean this was one night of music, and we were talking eight months away. And he just went on and on about how to make it happen. And that's when I learned, okay, his standards are partly accountable for the way he is.

EC: I learned a great deal, for better or worse, for better or worse, through all three of those cats, I am my father's son. You know. And when I say for better or worse I mean I can stir some shit up. And I'm doing it and having a great time doing it but at the same time it's not — sometimes people feel like you're sneaking up on them a little bit because it's hard to always be direct like that. It's hard to — it takes way too much energy to be like that all the time. So I think you just go in hoping that everything is going to be cool and so if you assume everything is going to be cool and be polite and be cool, that's great. And then as soon as something goes wrong it's always a bit of a drag when you kind of have to bite someone's head off. And like I say, for better or worse I think I learned that from all my mentors. But I miss him so much.

MR: It was a great shock.

EC: At the same time, when he died and also when Tony Scott died, it was shortly in that same period. And another good friend, Ahmet Ertegun when those guys passed away I did go through a period where I was feeling pretty sorry for myself and I had a friend remind me, how old are you? Meaning, really? That's what happens, this is what happens. Now Kenny was too young, but at the same time it's like okay, now you are no longer the student, you're no longer the kid, you're no longer the — circle of life, Simba. And then that's when I started to get a little more serious about viewing myself in the different contexts and trying to get a handle on some of the education things and trying to get a handle on what was happening in the community, trying to take more responsibility for my own music, that, and then of course this is all in a period this has all been in that last four years since Katrina, or since the flooding. And so all of that put together is sort of like yeah, okay, we can step this up and do things that are a little more interesting, a little more important. We don't have to make asses out of ourselves. It's okay to go home after the gig. So you go through the different — you kind of get to a different place, and I found once I embraced that a little more then it seemed kind of silly to feel sad that all these people had passed on. This is how it's supposed to happen.

MR: He kind of went out at the top of his game.

EC: I think so. I think so. At the top of his game, yet at the same time I think one of the things

[DiNicola] passed away before, just a few months before, the market for the jobs wasn't getting any better and the quality of the musicians that he was ending up sharing the bandstand with, unless it was his own quartet, which with the absence of Tony D it was not, you know I think things had taken a little bit of a change. So he as an individual may have been feeling really strong and I think he was really, I think he was pretty content in New Mexico. I mean he didn't like how dry it was but, so yes and no. He was feeling strong but there was a dearth of things to feel strong for. And I still recognize that. I mentioned, I don't do a lot of jazz parties and things like that.

MR: Well it's been fascinating talking to you.

EC: Thanks, Monk, I had a good time.

MR: I look forward to what happens on the bandstand.

EC: It's like one of my favorite subjects, clarinet, Kenny and music.

MR: Right.

EC: Well thanks for the opportunity to hang out with some of the kids, it was good. I have to make a habit of it. I've got to get some other New Orleans guys up here.

MR: Yeah. I'm going to ask you one more question that we can dub in. I'm expecting our tape to run out. I forget the circumstances, it might have been in one of the classes yesterday, you were talking about Lincoln Center and sort of this striving to make jazz, to bring it up to the level of how people think about classical music. And I'm wondering if that's sort of a fool's errand, because the musics are not the same — I can't even finish my question.

EC: I think it's a double edged sword to try to — look we're in the period where there's a level of alienation from the arts in general that's high enough that I don't think we need to make it worse by re-framing jazz or by continuing this track of framing it as a higher art. I mean I think all of it needs to be brought down through education, that's how I would do it, to a level where the function of the music is not only more evident but viewed as essential. I think it's not only jazz that needs to be returned to its place, but I think more of an effort needs to done with all the different types of musics and art: classical music, opera, I think we'd need to really be serious about how we — what strategies we can recognize in the music. And in jazz the strategies are much more evident. The strategies about how we solve problems creatively and how we express our individuality in the service of community and how certain vertical disciplines of getting better at the craft have to resonate also with horizontal movement, meaning the circle has to be spreading out and the potency of the music has to be in its — not only in its expressive potentialities but in its potential to engage, to inspire. It just needs to be brought down to a vaguely more human level that I don't think you achieve when you try

obligatory cultural experiences. But I think classical music needs to kind of have the same battle. I think especially when the economy is like this. You can't continue to kind of act like the audience's concerns aren't important in a way, as if what you're doing is so important that oh, they'll come when they figure it out. You know I think we need to equally present ourselves as artists. Not just jazz, but I think we need to put ourselves on doorsteps for people and say here we are. Like we can help you. This music is here to help you. It's here to heal you. It's here to — we can say, we're here to serve in a way. And to our kids, to our youth. I think all the musicians, no matter what style you're playing: jazz, classical, or anything, I think as artists we need to be saying come check this out. Don't mess with that over there. That will kill you. I've got something that you'll like. I mean we can save some lives with this. Taking away these outlets for them to express themselves, for them to understand their own community, for them to foster respect for other individuals, for them to foster respect for themselves. You take away the arts and you've eliminated some very important avenues in which those things can happen. So yeah, there's a definite problem. And here's the contradiction. Even if Lincoln Center is doing some of those kinds of educational activities, what happens at the end, even if you have those kids saying, "Wow, that is kind of cool" and then you want them to go to Lincoln Center for a concert, there's a bit of a disparity. I mean that's not their audience. That's not my audience. I've been to Dizzy's Club a couple of times, and I've been to a couple of Lincoln Center concerts and I've been to a couple of concerts on the road, but just look around. Really? And it's not that I'm saying people aren't getting anything out of the experience. I'm not saying that they're only going there as a, what do they call it, some type of cultural experience that they have to do to feel like yes I support the arts and I'm cultured. Or even in a more condescending way. "I support jazz. Some of my best friends are black." It's that level of condescension in a way. And either way it's completely, it's antithetical to the true jazz experience. The true jazz experience embraces the primacy of the moment. It doesn't make presumptions about its importance before the fact really. If it does, wow, I don't have those kind of balls. You know? So I'm not sure how I feel about it. Economically, as a musician, it's made things very difficult. It's created this sense, for booking agents, there's this top tier and there's this top tier and there's this price range for like Lincoln Center, and then there's this low tier for cats like me, where the best we can expect is a few hundreds of dollars for an engagement. And there's not a whole lot in between. There's not a whole lot in between. And I think that's one of the effects that this has had, just from the marketing, from the standpoint of the marketing of the music. It's like you either have some jazz stars, and most of them aren't veterans, because most of the veterans are gone, and there's only a handful out there that

Coleman. There's a handful. But there's not. So if you don't have giants then you've got people that are just being marketed very well. And if that becomes sort of your top tier, and everybody else is kind of on the bottom, there's this huge hole in the middle. There's $5,000 and less, and $50,000 and more. But in between it's a little tricky. And I don't know if that was intentional.

MR: It's a result.

EC: It's an economic result.

MR: Yeah.

EC: The market has definitely changed as a result of their kind of — and it's also changed the marketing of the music and the make-up of what's being marketed. I'm tired of looking in the jazz magazines and seeing everything is a freaking tribute to something else. Like really? I had somebody want to do that recently. They were going to do a repertory concert. You know, of the Hot Fives and Sevens. Well you don't want me for that, trust me. This was the Benny Goodman centennial, which for me, the best thing about the Benny Goodman centennial was that we're only a year away from the Artie Shaw centennial. But that's the best thing for me. But it's just, even albums. I mean really? There's a conservatism about that that concerns me. I mean Kenny would be much more blatant about it. He'd call it necrophilia. And I don't necessarily entirely disagree.